Nonetheless, India had little choice but to maintain the Soviet option. So Gandhi and other officials tried to temper public anger. When some cabinet members wanted to cancel the Indian president's scheduled state visit to Moscow in protest, others like Morarji Desai and Defense Minister Swaran Singh calmed them down. Gandhi also eventually reduced her public criticism of the Soviet-Pakistan relationship.

Even when anti-Soviet sentiment in India deepened as Soviet troops cracked down against reformists in Czechoslovakia that summer, the government avoided harsh criticism. Members of the public, party, and cabinet opposed the government's approach. A nonofficial resolution in the Lok Sabha expressed the country's "support and sympathy" for the Czech people. A cabinet minister even resigned over the issue. However, Gandhi, supported by her foreign minister, stayed the course, and, at the UN, India subsequently abstained from voting on a resolution condemning the invasion because the wording could not be changed from "condemn" to "deplore."[188]

The Look East Option

With one benefactor losing interest in India and the other showing a bit too much interest in Pakistan, Indian policymakers saw the writing on the wall. And they sought to decrease their dependence on the superpowers to the extent possible. This meant looking at other potential partners more closely.

There had been criticism that India had not been doing enough in Southeast Asia, especially given the Chinese challenge it shared with many countries in the region. Observers then and later criticized Gandhi's "abdication of responsibility in Asia." In 1966, Lee Kuan Yew, the first prime minister of Singapore, had complained about failing to get Gandhi interested in an "Asian regional arrangement to contain China." India had indeed been skeptical of regional organizations or coordination. It had demurred from joining the Association of Southeast Asia in 1961, the Greater Malayan Confederation (Maphilindo) in 1963, and the seventeen-nation conference on regional economic cooperation in April 1965. Subsequently, India had not joined the nine-nation Asian and Pacific ministers' conference in June 1966 or the October 1966 conference on Vietnam in Manila.[189] And foreign minister Chagla ruled out the idea of